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CHAPTER XII.

(Conclusion of the Chapter.

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FOREIGN CORRESPONDENCE.

Number LXXIII.

TAMSUI, FORMOSA, December 1st, 1873.

Rev. Mr. Campbell, of the English Presbyterian mission in Formosa, Mr. Bullock, of the English consulate at Taiwaufu, and I, set out from Taiwaufu on the fourteenth of October, for a trip into the interior of the island, Mr. Campbell being on his way to visit the mission stations near the center of the island. Our company consisted of ourselves, two servants, five coolies—for carrying our burdens—and three chair coolies with a chair, in case one of us should get tired out or sick.

The Chinese coolie divides his load, hangs half to each end of a bamboo, and starts off at a slow, swinging trot that we found some difficulty in keeping up with at a rapid walk; but at the end of a mile or two, the burden is dropped at one of the little booths erected at the side of the path, and often under the shade of a spreading banyan, and the coolie takes a cup of weak but very hot tea, or a bowl of rice, rests a few minutes and goes on again, the day's work being made up of a dozen or more of these short and hurried marches. At these stopping places we would divide a huge pumelo, or shaddock, between us, or would eat a few plantains, or oranges, and would then hurry on with the rest.

The country was rather too high for irrigation for a few miles after leaving Taiwaufu, and was planted in sweet potatoes and sugar cane, the latter a purple kind, small and with short joints, but very sweet. Sugar raising is rapidly growing in importance in the south end of the island, the raw sugar being shipped to the main land and Japan, and, in some cases, to England.

After passing this, we came into immense level plains, extending as far as we could see, divided by banks into little fields, and all irrigated and planted in rice, that was now just ready for harvest. The fields were full of men, women and children, some of the former cutting off the hills of rice with very small sickles, and putting it together in bundles; others carrying them to the threshers who stood before a great wooden tub that was nearly surrounded by a cloth reaching up six or seven feet to keep the rice from flying off. Slats were put over the tub, and upon these the rice in the straw was struck, and one or two blows so thoroughly cleaned it of grain as to leave little for the women to clean. The tub was carried about by poles to different parts of the field, and, when full, the rice was carried away in baskets to the drying floors,—spots of earth tramped hard and smooth—where it was spread out to dry. All of this country produces two and some of it three crops of rice yearly. The only thing to break the monotony of mile after mile of these rice fields were little clusters of bamboos scattered over the plain, and each of these concealed a dirty little Chinese town, with mud houses crowded together.

The Chinese are essentially town dwellers, going to the fields to cultivate and to reap, but returning to the towns at night. The only shelters in the fields are little huts built of grass or straw, in which some one stops at night to watch the crops from thieves or wild animals. How it may be in other parts of China I do not know; but one can pass through the island of Formosa without seeing anything to remind him of our farm houses, where families dwell by themselves upon their lands.

The road we were traveling, though the main thoroughfare between two large cities, was nothing but a narrow path following the divisions between the fields and winding about, so that, after a hurried and tiresome day's march, we found ourselves scarcely twenty miles from Taiwaufu. We passed the first night, which was much of a piece with those that followed, at a Chinese inn or stopping place, in the town of Hoisiutiam. We were given a dirty little room with an earth floor, only separated by a bamboo screen from a pig sty, while the whole establishment was filled with the smell of opium from those who were smoking it. We were brought eggs and rice, and with preserved meats that we had brought along, we made a good supper, and went to bed too tired to mind the hosts of crawling things that are accustomed to take their toll from sojourners at Chinese inns.

The second day we passed through much such a country as the first, seeing in some places fields of pea nuts, which women were digging, sitting on the ground and using sharp sticks, droves of hogs were gleaning what were overlooked, and boys watching them that they should not trespass. The women wore over their heads a piece of blue cloth that was tied under the chin, looking much like old-fashioned hoods. They had curious, rough shoes of palm leaf, to keep their little feet from sinking too far into the mud which covered the fields. We saw a few fields of a large plant, from which a coarse hemp for ropes is made; but the staple crop as before was rice. I had seen frequently in the markets at Canton and Hongkong a curious nut, shaped almost exactly like a bull's head and horns, and found it growing here in ponds, it being the fruit of a water plant.

The second night we stopped near the walled city of Kagee, which is said to contain from thirty to sixty thousand people. It has walls of several miles in circumference, strongly built of brick and stone, and broad enough on top to enable four or five horsemen to ride abreast. The gates are fortified with a second wall and outer gate. Though probably built within the last century, it is not protected by cannon, nor planned for defense against them; but seems to be the exact model of walls built by the Chinese thousands of years ago.

Historians who wish to clear up doubtful points in regard to fortifications and defense in early and pre-historic times, would do well to visit China, for they would, in all probability, find the same style of fortifications now in use that Homer describes as surrounding Troy, though the Chinese soldiers carry firelocks, and, in some cases, are armed with rifles and sword bayonets; but their preferment does not depend upon skill in their use, but upon their skill in using the bow and the spear.

Kagee is back near the base of the mountains, and without canals or other means of communication, except foot paths, and why so many persons have gathered together in it is hard to say.

The third day we were on our way before daylight, the stars still shining, and morning gradually coming over the Eastern mountains. We left the road to Tamsui on the left, and turned to the north-east, and passed the third night at a village just at the foot of the mountains. We had now reached the neighborhood of the savages, and all the parties of Chinese we met were armed with knives and guns.

The fourth day we passed up a stream that led out from the mountains, and we were all day climbing up and down among the hills, part of the time among tree ferns and other tropical vegetation, and then on hill sides covered with tall grass, where the Chinese had cut the timber off to drive out the savages. Camphor stumps and logs became frequent, though the trees had been cut down generally for that portion which would make good planks. We were frequently pointed out places where the Chewhan, as the savages are called, had come down and cut off the heads of a few defenseless Chinamen, and again retreated to their forests.

Upon the morning of the fifth day's journey, we met a party of Tsuiwhan, a tribe of savages who have given up their head-hunting proclivities, and now live at peace with the Chinese. The poor fellows knelt down in the path before us, and looked as if they were ready to kiss the ground we stood on if we should wish it. They were clothed in poor, ragged hunting shirts of tanned skins that reached to the thigh, leaving their legs bare. They were armed, part of them, with old Chinese firelocks, and the rest with bows and arrows. They are small, but much finer featured than the Chinese, and are without the oblique eyes and inverted eyelids that characterize the Chinese proper.

After two or three hours' walk we came to a large valley, with a lake two or three miles in length in its midst. This valley and lake had been the exclusive property of the Tsuiwhan, and they have several villages about it; but the Chinese are steadily encroaching and buying the best lands for a song of the poor savages, who have the genuine Indian love for strong drink, and will part with anything to get it. As we came down to the bank, we could see a solitary savage fishing with a net among the pond lilies. Upon the promise of some tobacco he paddled slowly and cautiously to the shore, and we had a chance to examine his boat and fish. The boat was a large camphor log hollowed out, apparently by fire, and seemingly some centuries old. There were no ends to it, and to keep the water from flowing in he had put in clay. Five or six small cat fish or bull heads, much such as are found in western mill ponds, lay in the bottom of the boat, with a few shells, apparently anodons.

When news arrived at the other end of the lake of our coming, the old chief sent up a canoe much as the first, but some thirty or forty feet in length, and we embarked with our baggage. The lake is very pretty, being surrounded on all sides with mountains, those on the east still covered with virgin forest, while those on the west have been encroached upon by the Chinese and robbed of much of their timber.

The principal village of the Tsuiwhan is upon the west side, and there we landed, the old, white-headed chief and all the tribe—men, women and children—turning out to welcome us, shaking our hands and saying "*penan*," as near as they come to the Chinese *pengan*—peace. The Chinese never shake hands, and this is either an old custom of the aborigines of Formosa, or learned from the Christians.

We were immediately conducted to one of their houses, a large barrack of bamboo covered with grass, and with four or five fires upon the earthen floor in different parts, and as many low bamboo platforms, serving for beds and homes for as many different families. About the post that supported the roof in the center were placed the firelocks, bows and arrows, and other paraphernalia of war or hunting. There were also strings of skulls of monkeys, wild boars, deer, and other game, carefully preserved and hung up.

Mr. Campbell left us here, and went on to the mission stations, while Mr. Bullock and I remained for a few days to hunt and collect about the lake. We were somewhat troubled for a place to stop; but an old Chinaman, the principal man of the place, took us in and cared for us. I employed the boys, both Chinese and savages, to collect for me, and was soon filling the cans of spirit I had brought all the way from Taiwaufu, with fish, snakes, crabs, etc. We often paddled about the lake, but got little else besides a small species of grebe, that was in great plenty. We also got a few fine butterflies, the little boys of the village accompanying us, and bringing in large quantities of grasshoppers, mantis, and other insects.

The whole race, from the chief down, proved to be great beggars, and were continually at our room; but as we wished to see as much as possible of them, and I was trying to write some of their language, this did not matter. They have a curious custom of knocking out the upper teeth on each side the two middle ones, leaving these to stand alone like those of a squirrel. This seems to be only done with the boys, and when they are about reaching man's estate.

It was the time of the rice harvest, and most of the Tsuiwhan were engaged in helping the Chinese in the harvest, probably to pay up some debts made before. Men and women were engaged in cutting and threshing, while several of the men were carrying the threshed rice on their backs to the village. As they tramped along under their burdens, they kept up a monotonous but musical oh—ho—oh—ho—that sounded far off over the hills and lake. I heard a company of boys at one time singing a wild, strange roundelay, that would make Barnum's fortune, if he could transport them and their music to the United States. They seem to be a very musical race, and the contrast is great between them and their Chinese neighbors and masters.

J. B. STEERE.

Gentle Woman Roused.

A Story of the Temperance Movement in the West.

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